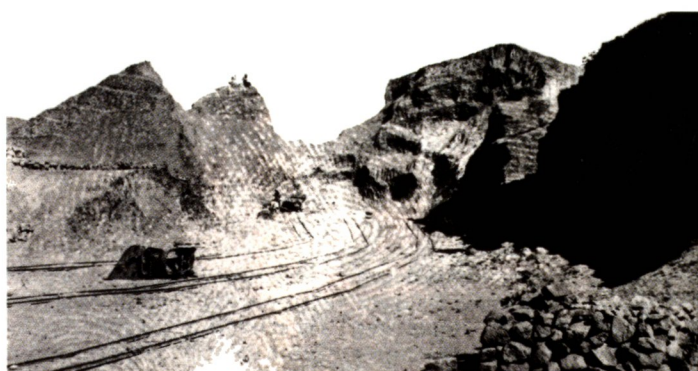
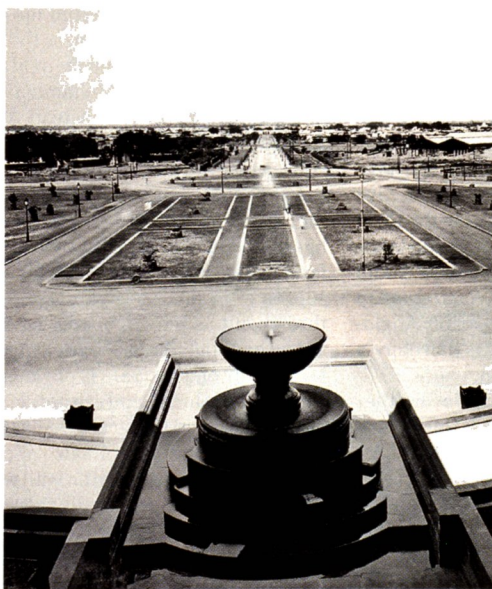
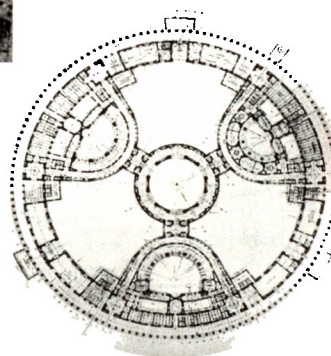




(EXTREME LEFT) AN AERIAL VIEW OF INDIA GATE THEN; THE MASSIVE ROCKS OF RAISINA HILL WHICH WOULD BE REPLACED BY THE IMPOSING STRUCTURES OF GOVERNMENT BUILDINGS OF NEW DELHI (LEFT)



(LEFT) A FOUNTAIN AT THE REAR OF SOUTH BLOCK; (BELOW) NORTH BLOCK APPROACHING COMPLETION; AND LUTYENS' CIRCULAR PLAN OF THE PARLIAMENT BUILDING (RIGHT)



rare archival material, as he has done here, from sources in London.

Which is where modern Delhi's story began, in secrecy, as it turns out. The decision to shift the capital of British India from Calcutta to Delhi was kept under wraps so it could be announced by King George during his Grand Durbar in India in 1911. The rest, as they say, is history but what a history! What sets this book apart is the incredible wealth of rare and unpublished material: letters, documents, telegrams, sketches, maps, parliamentary debates, newspaper articles, the original agreement between the Council of India and the two chief architects of Delhi, and above all, photographs dating back almost a century.

The choice of Malvika Singh to write the main essay is inspirational: her husband is the grand-

son of Shoba Singh, a key builder commissioned by Herbert Baker and Edwin Lutyens, the two architects, to build the new capital. It would cost Rs 13 crore and take 17 years to complete on the site chosen: Raisina Hill which had to be levelled so that the grand vision could be completed. The core of this book is the exclusive archival material but also the growing schism between Baker and Lutyens over the design and layout of some of the prominent buildings that define the city today. The making of a Capital was a fascinating odyssey, and so is this book. It explains the concepts behind the broad avenues, the grand buildings, the material used, the choice of greenery, the design and the layout. In the end, what it also represents is the return of valuable archives relating to Delhi and to India. Pramod Kapoor, take a bow. ■